With the world being what it is, self-interest and convergence cannot be fully counted upon to forecast the behaviour of others, including neighbours. Neither their ambitions and emotions nor their risk-taking propensity are always predictable. Few would have anticipated the sharpness of the downturn that India's relations with China have taken in the last three years. Any prudent polity, therefore, backs its posture with capabilities and deterrence.

A big responsibility of Indian diplomacy is to create the widest set of options for such contingencies. This could mean acquisition of defence equipment and other supportive measures; securing understanding for our policies and actions from the international community; and, for that matter, in mitigating or resolving more fraught situations. Let us look at how all of that has worked in the last few years.

A notable achievement of the Modi government was to conclude and implement the Land Boundary Agreement with Bangladesh in 2015. In conjunction with the resolution of maritime differences, this has had a positive impact on the security situation in the East. More than that, it has opened up possibilities for economic cooperation and connectivity for the entire sub-region. The beneficiaries are not just India and Bangladesh with respect to trade and travel or Nepal and Bhutan for the same but the northeastern states of India as well, and that also to a very significant degree.

A very different challenge is being faced on our western boundary vis-à-vis Pakistan. On that front, the initial goal of diplomacy was to expose and de-legitimize Pakistan's cross-border terrorism. When counter-actions were required, as in Uri in 2016 and Balakot in 2019, effective diplomacy ensured global understanding of India's actions.

As far as China is concerned, the diplomatic negotiations that are going on in parallel to the military stand-off since May 2020 illustrate that foreign and defence policies are really joined at the hip. Here, too, the value of global support and appreciation is self-evident. The leveraging of a multipolar world has been particularly visible in terms of weapons and technologies needed by our defence forces. That a Rafale aircraft acquisition from France can take place in the same timeframe as that of an MH-60 helicopter or P-8 aircraft from the US, the S-400 missile system from Russia and SPICE bombs from Israel speaks volumes of our nimbleness. These are typically accompanied by military exercises and